ALI NIAZI

Email: ali.niazi@ucalgary.ca | Website: aliniazi.com | LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/niazi-ali

CONTACT INFORMATION

Office Address
Department of Economics, University of Calgary
SS 405, 2500 University Drive NW
Calgary, AB T2N 1N4, Canada

Placement Director
Dr. Atsuko Tanaka
atanaka@ucalgary.ca
+1 403-220-6709

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Energy and Environmental Economics, Empirical Industrial Organization, Applied Microeconomics

DOCTORAL STUDIES

Ph.D. in Economics — University of Calgary *Expected completion 2026*

Dissertation: Essays in Energy and Environmental Economics

Dissertation Committee and References:

Blake Shaffer (Supervisor)
Department of Economics, University of Calgary
blake.shaffer@ucalgary.ca

David Brown
Department of Economics, University of Alberta
dpbrown@ualberta.ca

Erica Myers
Department of Economics, University of Calgary
erica.myers@ucalgary.ca

Lucija Muehlenbachs
Department of Economics, University of Calgary
lmuehlen@ucalgary.ca

PRIOR EDUCATION

M.Sc. in Economics — Sharif University of Technology *2020*

B.Sc. in Electrical Engineering — Ferdowsi University of Mashhad *2016*

WORKING PAPERS

Renewable Expansion and Strategic Behavior in Restructured Electricity Markets (JMP)

Do Gasoline Prices Influence Electric Vehicle Usage? Evidence from the U.S.
with Blake Shaffer

Electric Vehicle Charging and Driving Behavior
with David Brown, Blake Shaffer, and Mallika Sharma

The Reproducibility and Robustness of Economics and Political Science (R&R, Nature)
with Abel Brodeur, Derek Mikola, Nikolai Cook, Lenka Fiala, et al.

PUBLICATIONS

Ali Ebrahim Nejad, Saeid Hoseinzade, and Ali Niazi (2024). "Credit Rating Agencies During the Credit Crunch." *Review of Financial Economics* 42: 124–147. doi:10.1002/rfe.1192

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant — University of Calgary *2021–2025*
with Blake Shaffer (2023–2025); Scott Taylor (2021–2023); Trevor Tombe (2022); Aidan Hollis (2022)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor of Record — University of Calgary *2024, 2025*
Computer Applications in Economics (ECON 311)

Teaching Assistant — University of Calgary *2021–2024*
Principles of Microeconomics (3 terms); Macroeconomics II (2 terms); Engineering Economics (1 term); Computer Applications in Economics (6 terms)

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Market Fundamentals Analyst — Alberta Electric System Operator (AESO) *2025–present*
Research Analyst (Part-time) — Energy Futures Lab *2024–2025*
Research Analyst (Part-time) — Smart Prosperity Institute *2024–2025*

HONORS & AWARDS

Eyes High International Doctoral Scholarship (CAD $15,000), University of Calgary *2025*
Doctoral Research Scholarship, University of Calgary *2023–2025*
International Tuition Award, University of Calgary *2020–2025*
Macroeconomics Prize, University of Calgary *2021*
Economics Scholarship, Agricultural Bank of Iran *2017–2018*
Excellence Scholarship, Ferdowsi University of Mashhad *2015*

SEMINARS & CONFERENCES

2025: Canadian Economics Association Annual Conference (Montreal); Electricity Lunch Research Seminar (Calgary)
2024: Canadian Economics Association (Toronto); Environmental Econ Workshop (London, ON); Electricity Lunch Research Seminar (Calgary)
2023: Canadian Economics Association (Winnipeg); Canadian Resource and Environmental Economics Association (Winnipeg)

SERVICE

Referee, *Canadian Journal of Economics* *2024*
Researcher, Net Zero Electricity Research Initiative *2022–present*
Co-organizer, Grid Forward Conference *2024*
Co-organizer, Electricity Camp in the Rockies *2023–2025*
Co-founder, Graduate Economics Buddy Program *2022–2024*
VP Finance, Economics Graduate Association *2023–2024*

SKILLS

Programming & Tools: R, Stata, Python, Julia, MATLAB, LaTeX
Languages: English (fluent), Persian (native), French (learning)

ABSTRACTS

Renewable Expansion and Strategic Behavior in Restructured Electricity Markets
Job Market Paper

The expansion of renewable energy is reshaping price formation and strategic behavior in restructured electricity markets. This paper quantifies the impact of wind and solar on wholesale prices, market power, and generator profitability. Using data from Alberta's electricity market, I construct an hourly cost-based competitive benchmark from unit-level marginal costs and decompose price effects into cost and markup components. I find that renewables lower average wholesale prices, but their effects on prices and market power are heterogeneous throughout the day. Wind reduces prices and markups in most hours, with larger impacts during high-demand periods. Solar, however, exhibits asymmetric effects. It reduces midday prices and markups but increases them during some morning and evening hours, creating new opportunities for strategic behavior. Counterfactual capacity scenarios indicate that renewable expansion shifts value from energy to flexibility. Inframarginal rents for renewables and baseload combined-cycle units fall, while scarcity rents concentrate into fewer hours, favoring fast-ramping units and storage. These findings demonstrate that adding renewable supply does not, by itself, eliminate market power. Robust market design and flexible resources are essential to keep decarbonizing grids competitive and reliable.

Do Gasoline Prices Influence Electric Vehicle Usage? Evidence from the U.S.
with Blake Shaffer

This paper examines how households with electric vehicles (EVs) adjust their charging and driving behaviors in response to short-term fluctuations in gasoline prices. Using a novel dataset of over 5,000 battery EVs across the U.S. from 2021-2022, we find that a 1% increase in gasoline prices is associated with a 0.35% rise in average daily EV miles traveled. This response is significantly stronger in areas with greater access to charging infrastructure, particularly DC fast chargers. We argue that this behavior primarily results from intra-household substitution within multi-vehicle households owning both EVs and internal combustion engine vehicles (ICEVs), where higher fuel costs shift miles between vehicles. Higher gasoline prices also increase the share of away-from-home charging, suggesting EV owners found new charging opportunities in response to higher gasoline prices. These results suggest that carbon taxes could increase EV usage, but their effectiveness depends on complementary investments in charging infrastructure. Our findings inform policies that leverage price incentives to reduce transportation emissions.

Electric Vehicle Charging and Driving Behavior
with David Brown, Blake Shaffer, and Mallika Sharma

In this paper, we examine the charging and driving behavior from over 6000 electric vehicles from 14 metropolitan areas across the U.S, for over 2.3 million charging sessions and 3.3 million driving trips. The study investigates when and where people charge, including the use of different charger types (level 1, level 2 or DC Fast) and the frequency of charging. We also explore the extent of EV usage and driving patterns, including annual vehicle mileage, trip length, and daily driving behavior. We observe peak midnight charging, with 66% of charging occurring at home and a mean start state-of-charge at 49%. EV users also charge four times in a typical week. They drive, on average, 16,392 km annually. They also tend to take longer trips during weekends, with an average of 46.7km per day compared to 43.5km on weekdays. These behavioral insights are critical for policy design shaping the transportation sector, charging infrastructural planning and energy management programs to support EV adoption and meet decarbonization goals.

The Reproducibility and Robustness of Economics and Political Science (R&R, Nature)
with Abel Brodeur, Derek Mikola, Nikolai Cook, Lenka Fiala, et al.

This systematic and large-scale reproduction effort provides the first evidence of the reproducibility and robustness of economics and political science fields. We reproduced and conducted robustness analysis of 110 articles recently published in leading economics and political science journals. We first find that 84% of published claims can be computationally reproduced. Second, our re-analyses lead to 79% of statistically significant estimates to remain statistically significant in the same direction. Third, the median reproduction's effect size is 100% the originally published effect size. Fourth, six independent research teams examined 12 pre-specified hypotheses about determinants of reproducibility and robustness. They found a negative relationship between reproducers' experience and reproducibility, but no relationship between reproducibility and author characteristics or data availability.